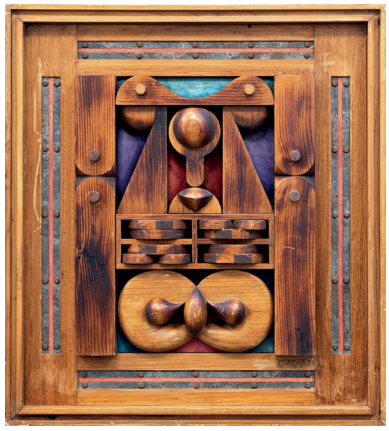




A VISUAL DIALOGUE Clockwise from left, untitled works by P.N. Mago (oil on canvas, 1946); Devyani Krishna (gouache on paper, 1951), 'Gossip' (painted PoP, 1960) by Dhanraj Bhagat; 'Untitled' (wood and mixed media, 1973) by Satish Gujral





ART ▼

REBUILDING ON CANVAS

DAG'S LATEST EXHIBITION TRACES HOW THE DELHI SILPI CHAKRA COLLECTIVE MOULDED THE TRAUMA OF PARTITION INTO A FOUNDATIONAL PILLAR OF INDIAN MODERNISM

It was a chance remark by noted cultural and arts administrator Ashok Vajpeyi that proved to be the catalyst in the making of *Drawing a Nation: The Delhi Silpi Chakra*, currently on view at the DAG, New Delhi. The exhibition positions the Delhi Silpi Chakra—formed in 1949 and arguably India's largest and longest-running artists' collective—as a window into the evolving relationship between creative expression and civic identity in postcolonial India. It traces the journey of artists who transformed the trauma of displacement into a visual dialogue with a newly independent state.

"While we have previously curated exhibitions on the Progressive Artists' Group, significant developments in Bengal, and Group 1890 (a radical modernist collective active in the mid-1960s), we felt that a chapter closer to home—rooted in the cultural history of Delhi—remained to be told with the depth it deserves," says Ashish Anand, CEO and MD, DAG.

The exhibition, he says, has also allowed them to present important works by artists whom they have not previously showcased, including P.N. Mago, a founding member alongside B.C. Sanyal, Kanwal Krishna, Dhanraj Bhagat and K.S. Kulkarni, whose vision was central to the group's ideology and activities. "Sanyal's works, in particular, evoke the trauma and nostalgia of displacement, offering a poignant reminder of the circumstances that shaped the collective's formation. To stage this exhibition in Delhi is especially meaningful—it honours a movement that not only emerged here but profoundly shaped the city's artistic and cultural landscape," he adds.

> The exhibition maps the **evolution of the collective's vision and highlights** how each new member inherited and reshaped its ethos

The show also includes such artists as Ram Kumar, Satish Gujral, Bishamber Khanna, Rameshwar Broota and Jagmohan Chopra. Chronologically structured, the exhibition maps the evolution of the collective's vision while highlighting how each new member both inherited and reshaped its ethos. Archival materials such as press reviews, exhibition photographs and documents have also been carefully integrated into the display.

Vajpeyi and art historian Atreyee Gupta played pivotal roles in putting the exhibition together. In a book published along with the exhibition, Gupta's essay traces the Delhi Silpi Chakra's emergence from the upheavals of Partition, showing how displaced artists forged a collective, civic-minded modernism in post-Partition New Delhi and within broader Global South imaginaries of modernism. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

On view at DAG, Delhi, till Mar. 21